

PUBLIC SUBMISSION

As of: March 21, 2025
Received: March 13, 2025
Status: [REDACTED]
Tracking No. m88-3b77-4s24
Comments Due: March 15, 2025
Submission Type: API

Docket: NSF_FRDOC_0001

Recently Posted NSF Rules and Notices.

Comment On: NSF_FRDOC_0001-3479

Request for Information: Development of an Artificial Intelligence Action Plan

Document: NSF_FRDOC_0001-DRAFT-1277

Comment on FR Doc # 2025-02305

Submitter Information

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General Comment

With thanks to the NITRD NCO and the OSTP:

I am a policy advocate with an academic background covering political science and international relations, and I have spent much of the last few years learning about AI and watching on in horror as we came closer to building systems that can outthink us. The US Government has a responsibility to keep Americans safe; therefore, responding to the emerging threat of smarter-than-human AI must be front and center of the administration's new AI Action Plan.

As an American, and a human being, I am deeply alarmed by the threat that superhuman artificial intelligence may soon pose to our nation and even our species. Although the vast majority of AI systems are safe and beneficial, efforts to build smarter-than-human AI could be cataclysmic. Thousands of scientists and industry experts— including figures like David Sacks and Elon Musk— have warned that we don't know how to control smarter-than-human AI, and that efforts to build these systems could cause global catastrophe.

To quote a 2024 paper coauthored by several of the world's leading computer scientists: "once autonomous AI systems pursue undesirable goals, we may be unable to keep them in check [...] in open conflict, AI systems could autonomously deploy a variety of weapons, including biological ones [...] this unchecked AI advancement could culminate in a large-scale loss of life and the biosphere, and the marginalization and extinction of humanity." (Bengio, Hinton et al, "Managing Extreme AI Risks Amid Rapid Progress," Science, 2024).

By all means, we should lead in cutting-edge specialized AI innovation— with benefits in medicine, science, productivity, and more. But efforts to build smarter-than-human AI risk culminating in what Trump's AI Czar David Sacks termed a "potential successor species." We control the world because of our intelligence — if we build something smarter than us, losing control is a likely result.

An "arms race" to build smarter-than-human AI is a race with no winners — the US will not benefit from being the first to build rogue AI that destroys us. Instead, America must lead in negotiating an AI Deal: an international agreement to prohibit developing smarter-than-human AI, until we know how to control it, while encouraging specialized AI innovation.

History has much to teach us about this approach. President Reagan demanded that the Soviets negotiate on nuclear weapons, because he realized that a nuclear war has no winners — a few years later, the US and USSR signed a treaty prohibiting intermediate-range ballistic missiles. The President should adopt a similar approach when it comes to superhuman AI, demanding that China agree to negotiate to prevent its development.

If we act now, and decisively, we can secure the American— and human— future for generations to come.

Thank you for your consideration,

Felix De Simone

Concerned citizen and AI policy advocate